

hind Just Dial. While in Delhi, he was approached by a friend to start a publication on wedding planning. "I collected enough cash to survive for a year-and-a-half and began working on Just Dial," says Mani.

With the telecom liberalisation in 1996, the number of land-line connections soared in India and the mobile revolution was ready to take off, but the lack of funds was a big pothole. "No bank was ready to fund an idea that hadn't been tried before," he says. The only hope came in the form of their first number, which eventually helped getting numbers in the rest of the country effortlessly. From 1996 to 1999, he created a presence in Delhi, Bangalore, Hyderabad and Mumbai. In 1999, dot-com services were burgeoning and PricewaterhouseCoopers wanted to fund his online venture. "But I wasn't sure if it was possible with the available infrastructure," says Mani, who was later approached by an Indian dot-com company. "I sold them a part of my personal shares for cash and promised to sell the balance of shares once they got listed in NASDAQ. But soon after, the market went bust and many businesses shut their operations," says Mani. That's when he took a sabbatical and travelled the world for a year and returned in 2002 while his two brothers handled the company.

"It was the time for new approaches, listing models and premium services. The profits soared considerably and so did Just Dial," says Mani, who began with low prices for small-scale businesses. "The established companies didn't think they needed a service like ours to advertise for them. There were

thousands of small-scale firms that wanted to be future 'biggies'. It was a mutual growth, they invested in us and we put them on the charts," he says. Clients who began with an investment of Rs 1,000 are now investing big sums due to the multi-fold response.

Many investors followed, technology upgraded and expanded, but Mani's vision remained constant—providing higher output to customers for lower prices. Today, the Just Dial website has more than one lakh visitors daily, receives two lakh calls, and is spreading to international markets like the US with 1-800-JUST-DIAL number already in place. "If you're passionate about an idea, believe in yourself and go for it and don't think about the ifs or buts," says Mani. So the next time the city overwhelms you, pick up the phone, punch in your round-the-clock city guide number and let Just Dial do the rest. **by Purvi Malhotra**

success MANTRA

Believe in something,
be passionate about
your cause and have
complete faith in yourself

biggest OBSTACLE

Lack of capital, as no
bank was willing to
fund an idea that
hadn't been tried or
tested before

role MODEL

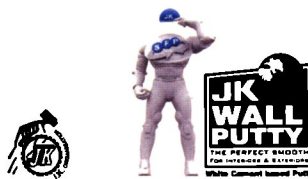
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his ability to think
ahead and J.R.D. Tata
for his business ethics

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- Protects against dampness
- Prevents flaking



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